women. The entire zenana deorhi would be routinely involved in the rituals of ‘vrats’, fasts, which punctuated the seasons. Akbar, too, started keeping fasts regularly and the number of days of fasting increased steadily throughout his reign, though he never imposed it on his subjects. ‘Of the austerities practised by my revered father,’ wrote Jahangir in his memoir, ‘one was not eating the flesh of animals. During three months of the year he ate meat, and for the remaining nine contented himself with Sufi food…’ Some of the specifically vegetarian dishes made for Akbar, as noted by Abu’l Fazl, included khushka, plain boiled rice; pahit, lentils cooked with ghee, ginger, cumin seeds, and asafoetida; khichdi, made of equal parts rice, mung dal, and ghee; and thuli, sweet, spicy cracked-wheat porridge.

Vegetarianism was a common trait amongst Rajput noblewomen, even when the men ate meat. For the men, especially the Rajput aristocracy, game was a highly appreciated food and there were numerous recipes for cooking shikar, ‘such as boar cooked with onions, coriander, cumin, garlic and ginger over an open fire’. Among the vegetarian dishes, a favourite was the dal batti churma, which consisted of a dal made from five kinds of lentils cooked in ghee, battis which were wheat-flour balls roasted in coals until hard, then cracked open and eaten with ghee, and churma which was ground wheat crushed and cooked with ghee and sugar. Besides his Hindu wives, there were others who introduced Akbar to greater austerity in his eating habits—the Hindus at his court, notably Birbal and Todar Mal, and the religious groups such as the Jains and the Jogis. But one of the very first times that Akbar would come into contact with fasts and the careful control over food in religious practice would be in the intimacy of the zenana, with his Rajput wives. Indeed, one of the first instances of Akbar taking a vow of austerity was when Harkha Bai was expecting Salim and failed to notice a quickening in her womb on a Friday. The anxious Padshah immediately declared that he would never hunt again on a Friday, to ensure the good health of his much longed-for child.

In the early years, when Akbar visited Sikri, he stayed, according to Abu’l Fazl, ‘in the lodgings of Shaikh Salim’. Badauni adds that ‘[Shaikh Salim] allowed the Emperor to have the entrée of all his most private apartments’ and that this led to some dismay among his sons and nephews who complained that ‘our wives are becoming estranged from us’. Badauni’s bracing conclusion from this was that you ‘either make no friendship with an elephant driver, or make a house fit for an elephant’.